

Logical positivism



Founded by philosopher Moritz Schlick (left) in 1922, the Vienna Circle also included mathematician Hans Hahn and sociologist, economist and philosopher Otto Neurath.

Thanks to Russell, Frege's work on logic reached a wider readership. By the 1920s, it was not only British thinkers who incorporated the new logic into their philosophy: a group of scientists and mathematicians known as the Vienna Circle formed with the aim of establishing a philosophical basis for science. They believed that it is the job of science, not philosophy, to provide truths about the world, but the job of philosophy is to provide a

logical framework in which science can work. The view they developed, logical positivism, applied the techniques of logic to the statements of science in the same way that analytic philosophy approached philosophical statements. To talk clearly and objectively about scientific ideas and theories, we must first analyse the language of scientific statements as logical propositions to ascertain their meaning, ruling out any that are meaningless. For the logical positivist, a statement can be accepted as true only if it meets strict logical criteria and can be empirically verified; anything else cannot be proved and so is effectively meaningless.